

Charting the Design Space for Platform Cooperatives

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Abstract

Platform cooperatives have recently emerged as an alternative to traditional capitalistic platform models. They aim to create economic value for their members and contribute to the social sustainability of the (local) communities, and, consequently, have been regarded as a more beneficial form of the sharing economy. Our research explores the characteristics related to fairness and equity in platform cooperatives as an initial step. Guided by prior work, we identified nine key fairness criteria and analyzed 30 platform cooperatives, mapping their characteristics into a taxonomy. We subsequently interviewed 17 members of three platform cooperatives to reflect on these fairness categories within their platforms. Our findings highlight the importance of equity, trust, and a sense of community for platform cooperative members to ensure fairness. Ultimately, we draw a set of design recommendations for each taxonomy criterion, offering practical guidance for platform owners and user experience designers to bolster fairness within platform co-ops.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → Empirical studies in HCI.

Keywords

Platform cooperatives, Fairness, User Experience

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1 BACKGROUND

The sharing economy [3, 27] has become an umbrella term for social, economic, and business models that rely on networked technologies to enable access to shared resources. Popular sharing economy services (e.g., Airbnb, Uber) generate economic activity by matching providers and consumers to optimize resource use (e.g., apartments, vehicles) or brokering on-demand labor (e.g., Deliveroo,

JustEat). These traditional sharing economy services and ubiquitous online delivery platforms are often subsumed under the term *platform capitalism* [28] for their emphasis on profit generation and returns to investors. Many of these services facilitate digital transactions on their platforms with minimal social interaction and do not contribute significantly to social cohesion [15]. Popular services like Uber and Airbnb have faced criticism for their adverse effects on individuals and society, including discrimination [11] and gentrification [33], and unethical labor practices such as precarious employment [32]. Other studies have raised concerns about personal data and privacy regarding extractive data practices for monetization [21, 34]).

In contrast, there has been a recent rise of *platform cooperatives* (co-ops) – technology-driven member-owned organizations that advocate for social, economic, and environmental sustainability in the (local) communities in which they operate [2, 19, 25]. They are distinguished by their adherence to the International Cooperatives Alliance (ICA) principles [17] which emphasize cooperative values such as democratic member control, autonomy and independence, cooperation, and concern for the community [34]. Platform co-ops are, therefore, deemed a fairer alternative to monopolistic platform-based companies as they enable distributed ownership, embed solidarity in the business model, provide better working conditions, and counter racial, gender, and other forms of discrimination [20, 34]. In addition to addressing members' economic needs, they aim to fulfill social and cultural needs of both members and the broader society [34]. However, given the novelty of the platform co-ops phenomenon (only nascent work exists in HCI [12, 29–31]) and the fact that it co-exists within digital capitalism, there are ambivalences and tensions [24] that impede understanding of the individual and societal advantages and values they offer.

This study aims to uncover characteristics of existing platform co-ops associated with fairness and equity and how their users perceive fairness. We attempt to chart this emerging design space. First, we identified key characteristics associated with fairness based on related work and considered nine categories. Second, we systematically analyzed 30 platform co-ops to discover specific design features associated with these categories. We subsequently conducted 17 interviews with users of Stocksy United, Posmo, and Flink platform co-ops to learn about their experiences and perceptions of fairness and its characteristics in these platform co-ops covering labor, mobility, and co-housing sectors, respectively. Based on our findings, we generated a set of design recommendations to bolster fairness in platform co-ops. In this work, we present a taxonomy of fairness-related features developed after analysis of 30 platform co-ops, synthesized themes from interviews and

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design recommendations for platform co-ops. This research contributes to the growing body of knowledge on design for platform cooperativism [12, 30, 31] and offers valuable empirical insights for user experience practitioners and researchers in the field of sharing economy platforms.

2 TAXONOMY

To identify characteristics of fairness in platform cooperatives, we turned identified nine categories from related literature. We then systematically examined these categories across 30 platform cooperatives.

Building upon the seven guiding principles of the International Cooperative Alliance [17], we decided to include the technological affordances for platform economies identified by Bødker et al. [1] and the principles of the Design Justice Network [9, 10]. This synthesis resulted in a classification that captures a broad range of fairness considerations, from cooperative ideals to technological mechanisms to social justice imperatives. Each source contributed a unique perspective, resulting in a comprehensive framework for analyzing and designing platform cooperatives.

We derived the following nine categories of fairness-related features for platform co-ops:

- (1) *Fairness and equal opportunities* - features that promote equal opportunities for users;
- (2) *Transparency* - features that inform users about the system's function (purpose) and functionality (process), increase the visibility of user activities on the platform and share information about licenses and copyrights [35];
- (3) *Flexibility* - ways of accessing and managing a platform and personal resources, along with the roles that members can take;
- (4) *User empowering* - design approaches that help to sustain, heal, and empower others, and center the voices of those who are directly affected;
- (5) *Collectivity* - features that support collective actions on the platforms;
- (6) *Non-discriminatory practices* - design practices that promote liberation from oppressive, exploitative systems and reconnect users to the earth and to each other;
- (7) *Trust* - features that increase trust in the purpose, process, and performance of the platform, i.e., System trust [8] and the ways of increasing trust between service receivers and service providers or other co-op members, i.e., Interpersonal trust [13];
- (8) *Benefits for community* - design practices that focus on reaching sustainable, community-led and -controlled outcomes;
- (9) *Sharing knowledge and learning opportunities* - ways of promoting education, knowledge sharing, and information exchange among community members.

To create a list of platform co-ops for our analysis, we consulted the related work [5] and followed Scholz and Schneider's rubric and explored non-profit groups, grassroots initiatives, member-owned organizations, and collectives that support cooperativism, are enabled by a digital platform, and have shared ownership and democratic control in the decision-making of the platform [26]. The following additional criteria were not mandatory but were also

considered throughout our selection process: alignment to the 7 principles of the International Cooperatives Alliance; creation of value for members, co-owners, and society; and promise of fairness and equal treatment of members. We produced a taxonomy linking the nine categories to fairness-related features in Notion¹. The taxonomy includes 30 platform co-ops that satisfied the defined criteria and were accessible for analysis. For each platform, the taxonomy provides general information and features classified by the categories.

3 INTERVIEW STUDY

We chose three platforms to investigate how people perceive and experience fairness in platform co-ops and conducted semi-structured interviews with their members. We chose the Posmo, Stocksy UNITED, and FLINK platform co-ops based on the diversity of their services covering mobility, labor, and co-housing sectors, respectively. Posmo is a data cooperative for mobility data based in Zurich, Switzerland. It collects and manages data about the mobility behavior of users as a basis for sustainable mobility in cities. Stocksy UNITED is a globally accessible, royalty-free stock photo and video agency based in Victoria, BC, Canada. FLINK is a management platform for housing cooperatives in Zurich. It offers a variety of services to housing cooperative administration and tenants.

3.1 Methodology

3.1.1 Participant recruitment. We recruited 17 participants (5 female, 12 male, 0 nonbinary) for interviews: 7 from Posmo (identified as P_P1..7), 8 from Stocksy (S_P1..8), and 2 from Flink (F_P1..2). For Posmo, we recruited people from our social network and asked them to use the platform for about one month before the interview. Participants from Stocksy were contacted through direct messages on Instagram or via email. We recruited Flink participants by distributing flyers about the study in Zurich housing cooperatives that used the platform. Our interviewees had been members of their respective platform co-ops for anywhere between 1 month and 13 years.

3.1.2 Data collection. The semi-structured interviews lasted between 30 and 40 minutes. Interview questions were designed to uncover participants' positive and negative experiences within the platform co-op, focusing on the nine fairness categories. We used screenshots of the respective platforms to present specific features to users, enabling us to collect their feedback.

3.1.3 Data analysis. The interviews were transcribed verbatim, anonymized, and translated into English when necessary. We then conducted a qualitative thematic analysis following methodology from [16] to identify patterns and synthesize themes. Our coding process employed both inductive and deductive approaches, assigning descriptive codes to quotes and, where applicable, linking them to the nine fairness categories. We initially created a coding tree to ensure coding consistency and sometimes worked in pairs to code the interviews. For data analysis and pattern identification, we selected codes related to specific characteristics, then categorized them based on semantic affinity and re-read the quotes to formulate

¹The full taxonomy is hosted at <https://www.notion.so/Platforms-a03acc86286a47159cb073e2c4b07d12?pvs=4>

subthemes. We used Dovetail software to aid the analytic process and visualized the data categories using affinity diagrams.

4 FINDINGS

The interviews' results corroborated that the nine fairness characteristics we initially identified were relevant and worth considering in platform cooperatives' design. This section presents our findings for each category and proposes design recommendations to bolster fairness in platform co-ops. We formulated design considerations as recommendations for platform owners and offered UI design elements to support them whenever possible.

4.1 Fairness and equal opportunities

Platform members first perceived platform fairness through the diverse representation of people, topics, work, and algorithms that treat everyone's work equally. S_P2: "there's a lot of interest for the diversity: climate, different countries, different parts of the world, [substantial amount of] women [contributors]." Designers, therefore, could *ensure equality in representation of different topics and people on the platform*. People will be more likely to stay on the platform if they believe they are being treated fairly. Example: An unbiased algorithm that equally represents different topics and people with diverse backgrounds.

Platform co-ops share profits with members, which was seen as fair. S_P7: "what attracted me to it [co-op] was the fact that they really shared the income with the members more fairly than the others." We encourage platforms to *provide detailed information about the profit-sharing process for cooperatives*. Transparency in profit sharing is critical for building trust between platforms and members. This could also motivate people to become members of the organization. Example: Clear information about how the cooperative's profits are distributed among its members. UI elements: informative documentation, financial reports, information page.

4.2 Transparency

Information transparency was one of the most important aspects perceived by platform users. They were interested in staying informed about updates and trends from the platforms; F_P1 mentioned: "I think [newsfeed is] the main thing of the app which I liked almost the most. There you see all the new things going on." Designers could *provide a variety of features to keep users informed*. Users may feel more connected if informed about the co-op and its latest news. A platform with easily accessible guidance for its features will simplify the user experience with that platform. Updates on trends in creativity platforms will assist users in meeting market demand. UI elements: blog, forum, newsfeed, FAQ, newsletter.

Platform co-ops' members highly appreciated the possibility of reviewing statistics on their actions, earnings, or voting results. P_P5 brought up CO2 emissions savings during their commute: "I think it's great. This bar really shows you on a scale from 1 to 10 how much emissions you [produce] while using this kind of transport." We recommend designers *make sure that users can review their statistics* though UI elements such as: dashboards with actions statistics (Figure 1, A), earnings statistics, community voting statistics.

A log of activities and checking the correctness of automatically detected activities and locations were critical for mobility data-sharing platforms like Posmo: "I checked it sometimes just to see how correctly it tracks my location" (P_6). Platforms should *ensure that users can check and adjust automatically collected data*. Users should be able to correct errors introduced by automatic data collection or hide information they do not want to share. UI elements: activities/locations history, manual correction/deletion option (Figure 1, B).

4.3 Flexibility

Users perceived the ability to sort, delete, and filter elements as offering flexibility. S_P7 explained: "On the website, you can sort your images in categories and groups, tag them, and attach all kinds of files, releases for people. In this sense, they are flexible." Designers could *allow users to customize their experience on the platform*. Customization of the platform better meets users' needs and makes the user experience more enjoyable. UI elements: filter and sorting functionality, customization elements: custom places. In some circumstances, it may not be possible to offer flexibility without compromising functionality. We recommend *providing clarification if user customization is not possible*. If users do not receive a rationale, they might abandon the functionality altogether. UI element: Information field (Figure 1, C).

4.4 Collectivity

Many platform co-op members liked the platforms' existing features which helped them connect with other users or get support when there were problems or questions. In their experiences, the platform co-ops promoted a sense of community, F_P1 put it simply: "I really liked that you can connect with some people with common interests within this [housing] cooperative." Designers could consider *providing means for users to establish and maintain social networks and receive support from other members of the platform*. This functionality can create trust between members and promote their sense of belonging in the community. UI elements: Forums, chats, internal blogs, Slack channels, groups or direct messages, event calendar (to organize physical meetings).

Members also valued the opportunity to participate in co-ops' organizational and strategic decisions, to propose initiatives, and to take part in collective decisions. S_P8: "As a contributor, I can make a community proposal about the website, whatever I like. And all the other contributors can vote in favor or not. So, it's not just about taking pictures and uploading them. It's about everything together." *Provide a tool to support group decision-making* as many interactions between members occur online, an online decision-making tool would be a viable solution. UI elements: Online decision-making tools: topic proposal tool (Figure 1, D), voting tool (Figure 1, E), moderation/membership request tool (Figure 1, F).

4.5 Trust building

When platforms are transparent in what they do with data and provide some documentation of their activities, they can build trust with their users: "I would say it's transparent in regard to the leadership and to major decisions because people vote on them, and every year they make a report of the earnings for that year and

what was successful, what wasn't successful" (S_P7). *Be transparent about the cooperative's goals and activities* and provide information on how data is handled, how the platform deals with potential profit, who is making important decisions, and their outcomes. This information can build initial trust, which may lead to more users joining the platform and higher user retention. Examples: Publish yearly financial reports; have a clear privacy policy. UI elements: FAQ, board members' information page.

Seeing a platform's partner organizations or sponsors can also give rise to trust. Some users mentioned that governmental organizations as partners made the platform look more trustworthy to them. The fact that Posmo and Flink are local platforms also helped to build trust. F_P2 appreciated that "it is not actually a big company from abroad that has a product here to make money, but it has been developed by people from the area practically for the special purpose of [housing] cooperatives." Designers could *bring attention to the connections and location of the platform*. Examples: If a local co-op is built for a local community, highlight the location; list partners and sponsors.

4.6 Benefits for the community

Users appreciated how platforms created awareness of environmental and social issues and valued the functionalities that addressed them: "CO2 is a very big topic. I think it is good that it is calculated and displayed in the app" (P_P2). However, many participants noted that they could not make sense of the data without a benchmark. Platform designers could *raise awareness of sustainability issues within the context of the platform*. In the context of mobility data-sharing platforms, this can be done in the form of numbers which show the personal impact on the environment compared to a benchmark. UI element: Behavior statistics with a benchmark (Figure 1, G).

Many participants were willing to help others or take action to benefit the environment. If platforms *provide functionality to assist them in tackling social and environmental issues* users might be encouraged to contribute more. Examples: This can be manifested through groups for sharing goods and services on co-housing platforms. In the creative industry, people in need can be promoted on forums and blogs to receive help.

4.7 Non-discriminatory practices

Members of platform cooperatives valued being part of an inclusive community and having opportunities to receive support: "When something happens that's not OK or that can harm you, you can always start [a] topic, contact others, and quickly you get some answers there" (S_P2). Therefore, platforms should *provide tools to support those who feel unsafe or discriminated against*, e.g., by introducing a moderator role. UI element: Support channel in forums for help with discriminatory experiences.

According to some participants, one way to avoid discriminatory practices on platforms is to be able to disclose only the information they feel comfortable sharing. Participant F_P1 said: "You know that you can choose who you interact with more closely and who is just the broader public, and you just want them to see limited amounts of data." Thus, designers, in line with privacy-by-design principles [7], should *allow flexibility in how much personal information users can*

disclose on the platform. Users should be free to choose which data they provide or disclose to the public. Different groups of people may prefer different levels of disclosure. UI element: Flexibility in profile disclosure (Figure 1, H).

4.8 User empowering

Many interviewees said they felt empowered by the ability to express themselves on their profile page. According to S_P1, this is done "first and foremost by the photos that they're taking. That is the most expressive way. You can add a bio to your profile; you can put email addresses." Designers should *Provide users the ability to present themselves on a profile page*, thereby encouraging their visibility and expressiveness. UI elements: Bio, links to social media, profile picture, videos, personalized header and background images, custom color schemes, fonts.

Our findings indicate that in-app currency or reward systems fail to maintain user interest or satisfaction effectively. P_P4 said about the Posmo currency: "I think in general its good. It could motivate you to use the app more, but [...] there was no any way to use it." P_P5 proposed to introduce personal milestones: "after you achieve something you pass a [personal] milestone and maybe even get a price." Designers should *include meaningful gamification elements*. Applying game design elements such as milestones, rankings, or badges meaningfully to the users' interests or activities can increase user engagement. UI elements: Milestones to achieve, badges, leaderboard (Figure 1, I).

4.9 Sharing knowledge and learning opportunities

Many interviewees agreed that platform co-ops could be a good place to learn something new or share knowledge with the community: "There is a contributor blog where we can work with each other. We can talk to each other and share information about any topic. It is a really good way to work with [other] contributors" (S_P8). Platform designers could *create a space where users can communicate and learn from each other*. Such features can contribute to users' personal development and make them feel a part of a community with shared interests and values. UI elements: Forum (communication about common topics), Webinar (content provided by others).

Some members had difficulties with the initial interaction with a platform or mentioned that certain features were challenging to discover: "There was missing something at the beginning, and it's been a slow journey of discovery. Even when I was preparing a little bit for our discussion today, I was looking at one or two of the features, and I thought, oh, I don't think I've seen that before" (S_P6). It is worth to *offer help for beginners and occasional users on how to use a platform*. A detailed guide to the available features would facilitate discovery of the platform's functionality and allow users to benefit from its features. UI elements: Onboarding walkthrough, tutorial video about the platform functionality.

5 DISCUSSION AND FUTURE WORK

Platform cooperatives, as member-owned organizations, present a compelling alternative to traditional gig economy models, prioritizing the common benefit of their members, using democratic

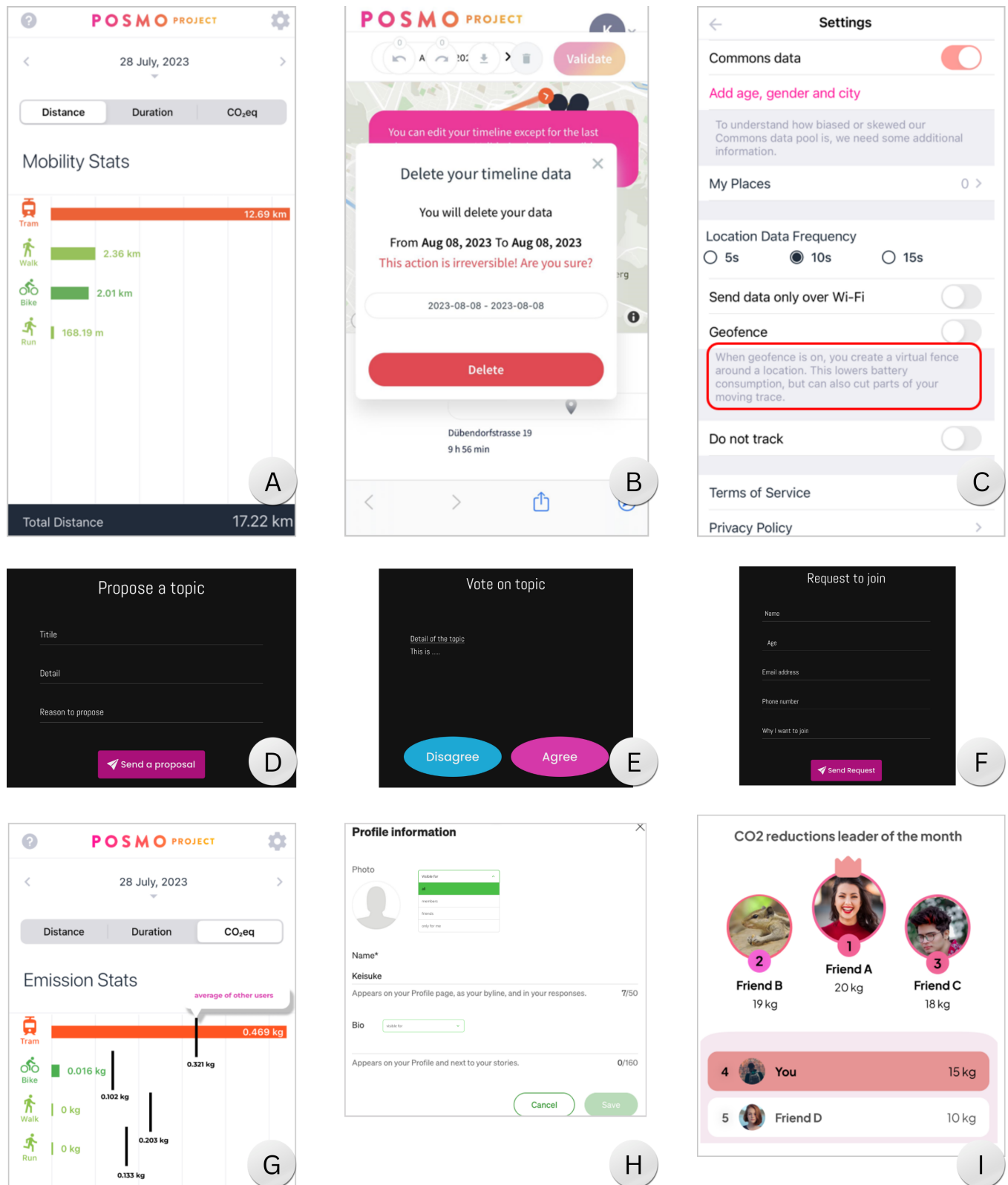


Figure 1: Examples of existing and new UI elements: A. Actions statistics (Posmo application), B. Deletion option (Posmo application), C. Information field (Posmo application), D. Topic proposal tool, E. Voting tool, F. Membership request tool, G. Behavior statistics with a benchmark (based on Posmo application), H. Flexibility in profile disclosure, I. Environmental leaderboard

governance, and creating value in local communities. This leads to more equitable working conditions, fairer distribution of profits, and a stronger sense of community among members [5, 19, 34]. Our interviewees viewed platform cooperatives as a preferable alternative to for-profit platforms, regarding better working conditions, more equitable compensation, and a sense of being valued rather than feeling treated like 'a number' as reasons for choosing platform co-ops. The members valued the platform co-op's moderation approach, which is more community-driven, transparent, and member-accountable, in contrast to for-profit platforms that construct utopian narratives to attract users and manage the platform's reputation [22].

However, platform cooperatives face challenges related to internal organization, capital acquisition, and external relationships, which can hinder growth and sustainability [19]. Platform cooperatives may struggle to achieve the same scale and network effects as their for-profit counterparts with greater resources and sophisticated algorithms [5], potentially limiting their reach and impact. On the one hand, to compete with for-profit platforms, platform co-ops should carefully choose their governance structures to balance democratic principles of participatory governance approaches [14] with the operational effectiveness of tiered governance [6]. On the other hand, researchers [18] have argued that scale might not be the right determinant of success in community-led sharing and collaborative economies and have examined the benefits of proliferation as an alternative pathway to achieving social change instead of growth by scale. In many platform co-ops, members have the opportunity to participate in organizational and strategic decisions through voting systems and proposal mechanisms [4]. This aligns with our findings that members value the ability to cooperate, propose initiatives, and participate in collective decision-making.

The characteristics of platform co-ops pose unique design challenges to maximize the individual and societal value [12, 30, 31], including the challenge for designers to adopt inclusive, equitable, and justice-oriented design goals [31]. Our research extends this base of knowledge by examining how HCI researchers can address these design challenges. To do so, we identified characteristics associated with fairness and equity through a literature review. We conducted interviews to determine how members of platform co-ops in labor, mobility, and co-housing sectors perceived fairness in the platform co-ops. We contributed to the body of work on shared economy platforms with a taxonomy that summarizes the platforms and how their features relate to the fairness characteristics we identified. We also synthesized interview themes and provided design recommendations based on our findings to bolster fairness and equity in platform designs.

In our future work, we will elicit feedback and evaluate the effectiveness of these design recommendations through further engagement with platform members through participatory activities beneficial for addressing information and power asymmetries [29]. We also intend to gain a comprehensive understanding of fairness and equity in platform co-ops by interviewing platform owners to understand their perspectives. Finally, future research could draw on our considerations and look into the design of alternative reputation and review systems for community-oriented (sharing economy) platforms that reflect cooperative values rather than competitive individualism [23].

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